TOOLBOX TALK — WEEKLY SAFETY METEETING

Millwork | Carpentry | Interior Finishes | Material Handling

WEEK 22

Date: ____________________ **Supervisor:** ____________________

Project / Job Name: ____________________

TOPIC: Silica Dust Awareness in Finish Work

OVERVIEW:

Crystalline silica is found in concrete, masonry, and some engineered stone countertops and tile substrates. Finish carpenters encounter silica when cutting, grinding, or drilling into these materials during installation or renovation. Silicosis — lung disease caused by silica dust — is irreversible and

TALKING POINTS — Read to Crew:

1. Silica dust is generated any time you cut, drill, grind, or abrade concrete, mortar, brick, or silica-containing stone. The dust particles are extremely fine — finer than wood dust — and penetrate deeply into the lungs where they cannot be cleared by the body's natural defenses. Over time, the body's inflammatory response to these particles creates scar tissue that progressively
2. The hierarchy of controls for silica exposure starts with engineering controls — wet methods and vacuum extraction — before respiratory protection. Wet cutting means applying water directly to the cutting blade or grinding wheel to suppress dust at the source. Vacuum extraction means using a tool-mounted vacuum with a HEPA filter to capture dust before it becomes airborne. These methods
3. If wet methods or vacuum extraction are not feasible for a specific task, a P100 half-face respirator is the minimum respiratory protection for silica-generating work. A standard N95 dust mask does not provide adequate protection against crystalline silica particles in high-exposure situations. Know which respirator you need before you start the cut.
4. OSHA's permissible exposure limit for crystalline silica is 50 micrograms per cubic meter as an 8-hour TWA. The action level — where additional controls kick in — is 25 micrograms per cubic meter. You cannot see or smell silica dust in air. You cannot tell by looking whether your exposure is within limits. The only reliable way to know is air monitoring. If you are doing repeated

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS — Ask Your Crew:

Q1: Which tasks on this current project involve cutting or grinding into concrete or masonry?

Q2: What silica control methods — wet cutting, vacuum extraction — do we have available on this site?

KEY SAFETY POINTS:

- Use wet methods or vacuum-equipped tools when cutting concrete or stone
- A P100 respirator is the minimum protection for silica-generating tasks
- Restrict access around all high-dust silica operations on the site
- Engineering controls (vacuum, wet) must be used before relying on PPE
- Know your site silica levels — the Action Level is 25 ug/m3 TWA

Crew sign-in sheet on page 2 — all 30 crew members sign on the following page.

CREW SIGN-IN SHEET

WEEK 22

By signing, I confirm I attended this toolbox talk and understand the topic discussed.

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